

The palette is inscribed with many of the symbols and traditions that would come to typify the pharaohs for the next three millennia. For instance, Narmer is shown holding an enemy by the hair, about to smite him, and Ramses II was often depicted in the same way—military might and supernatural strength were hallmarks of Egyptian kingship. The pharaoh, like the gods, was frequently shown much larger than ordinary mortals.

The geographical situation of Egypt—with its stark contrasts between the fertile Nile Valley and its delta, which empties in the north into the Mediterranean Sea, and the surrounding expanses of uninhabitable desert—gave rise to the kingdom's unique culture and civilization. The pharaoh was viewed as a living god who could control the order of the cosmos, including the annual flooding of the Nile, which brought fertilizing silt to replenish the soil. Pharaohs were also often depicted as farmers in agricultural scenes, representing their role as guardians of the land.

The Old Kingdom

The Old Kingdom that followed Narmer was ruled by a succession of dynasties that were led by powerful pharaohs, who channeled the bureaucratic and economic might of the unified kingdom into monumental building projects, such as the construction of the pyramids. These, in turn, stimulated scientific, technological, and economic development, increasing trade with other kingdoms in the Near East and the Mediterranean. In the Old Kingdom the predominant gods were Ra, the sun god; Osiris, the god of the dead; and Ptah, the creator. In the Middle and New Kingdoms that followed, which were ruled by families from Thebes, Amun became the main deity. As supreme ruler, the pharaoh was closely associated with the gods, and was believed to be the living incarnation of certain deities.

The New Kingdom

In the 22nd century BCE, the Old Kingdom collapsed. After what is known as the Intermediate Period, the Middle

Kingdom dynasties restored unified control of Egypt from 2134 BCE until around 1750 BCE, when they were invaded by the Hyksos (probably Semites from Syria). The Hyksos, in turn, were expelled from Egypt in about 1550 BCE, with the XVIII dynasty—arguably the greatest and most important—coming to power and establishing the New Kingdom. By this time, immortality was believed to be available not just to the pharaoh, but to priests, scribes, and others who could afford offerings, spells, and mummification, and many tombs were dug into the Valley of the Kings to be filled with extraordinarily rich grave goods.

Under expansionist pharaohs, such as Thutmose III and Ramses II, Egyptian control was extended into Asia as far as the Euphrates River, and up the Nile into Nubia. It was no coincidence that Ramses built Abu Simbel in Nubia: as well as representing the divine glory of Egypt's pharaohs generally, the temple was a symbol of Ramses' control over the recently conquered territory. ■

The **Nile Valley** is bordered by **inhospitable desert**, but is **highly fertile** because the longest river in the world flows through it and **irrigates it**.

A **sophisticated, coherent, and unified** civilization develops over a **vast stretch** of terrain.

Trade and conquest boost the economy and **population levels**. A large, prosperous kingdom emerges.

Vast monuments, such as the Abu Simbel temple complex, are constructed, reflecting Egypt's power, wealth, and belief systems.